Nicholas Nickleby

By Charles Dickens

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

INTRODUCTION

NARRATOR: *There once lived, in a sequestered part of the county of Devonshire, a mother, and a daughter and a son. Who, recently bereaved were forced to journey up to London. And to throw themselves upon the mercy of their only living relative, Ralph Nickleby. Ralph took Young Nicholas and found him a position in a school in Yorkshire run by Mr. Wackford Squeers, and arriving at the school, he met with the poor drudge Smike.*

Nicholas Nickleby by Charles Dickens.

NICHOLAS: Hallo. Please, don't be frightened. Are you cold? (Smike shakes his head) You're shivering.

SMIKE: Oh, dear. Oh, dear, oh, dear. My heart. Will break. It will. It will. I know it will.

NICHOLAS: Shh. Shh.

SMIKE: Remember Dorker, do you?

NICHOLAS: Dorker?

SMIKE: I was with him at the end, he asked for me. Who will I ask for? Who?

NICHOLAS: Who will you ask for when?

SMIKE: No One. No Hope. Hope Less.

NICHOLAS: There's always hope.

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SMIKE: Is there? O-U-T-C-A-S-T. A noun. Substantive. Person cast out or rejected. Abject. And forsaken. Homeless. Me.

NARRATOR: As the days wore on, Nicholas and Smike became friends.

SMIKE: Can't do it. With the book. Can't do it, with the book, at all.

NICHOLAS: Oh, please. Don't try. Don't For God's sake. I cannot bear it. They are more hard on you, I know. But, please...

SMIKE: Except for you, I die.

NICHOLAS: No, no. You'll be better off, I tell you, when I'm gone.

SMIKE: You gone?

NICHOLAS: Shh. Yes.

SMIKE: You going?

NICHOLAS: I was speaking to my thoughts.

SMIKE: Tell me. Will you? Will you go?

NICHOLAS: I shall be driven to it. yes. To go away.

SMIKE: Please tell me. Is away as bad as here?

NICHOLAS: Oh, no. Oh, no, there's nothing --

SMIKE: Can I meet you there? Away?

NICHOLAS: Well, yes... you can, of course...

SMIKE: Can meet you there? Away? And I would find you in away?

NICHOLAS: You would. And, it you did, I'd try to help you.

SMIKE: To go. Go anywhere. Go everywhere. The world's end. To the churchyard grave. I can. You'll let me. Come away with you. You are my home.

NARRATOR: It was a cold, foggy morning in early Spring, and a few meager shadows flitted to and fro in the misty streets. At intervals were heard the tread of slipshod feet, and the chilly cry of the sweep as he crept shivering to his early toil; the sluggish darkness thickened as the day came on,

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and those who had the courage to rise and peep at the gloomy street from their curtained windows, crept back to bed again, and coiled themselves up to sleep.

NICHOLAS: Now, listen to me, Smike. We're bound for Portsmouth, because it's a seaport town, and I am thinking we might board some ship. I'm young and active, so are you. Smike, do you have a good memory?

SMIKE: I don't know. I had once, I think. But now all gone.

NICHOLAS: Why do you think you had one once?

SMIKE: Because I could remember, when I was a child.

NICHOLAS: Do you remember, when you went to Yorkshire? What the day was like. The weather, hot or cold?

SMIKE: Wet. Very wet. And afterwards. When it was raining. I could see myself. The day I came.

NICHOLAS: Did you come there alone?

SMIKE: No. No. A man - a dark and withered man, they used to say. And I think I remember, too. Remember - being frightened of him. Glad he went away. But frightened at the place he left me, too.

NICHOLAS: Do you remember anything or anyone or anywhere, before that house in Yorkshire? Think, Smike, think.

SMIKE: A room. I slept once in a room a large and lonesome room, beneath the attic, there was a hook in the ceiling above me. I was frightened of it, covered up my head. Used to dream. Dream terribly about the room. And people in it. Things, that changed. But that room - never changes. Till now, I have not known two days together, when I haven't been afraid.

NARRATOR: At Portsmouth, Nicholas and Smike joined the theatrical troupe of Vincent Crummles and family. The time spent in this company was the happiest they had known. Eventually, however, the two wanderers were

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re-united with Nicholas' mother and sister. And Smike grew daily weaker. There is a dread disease which so prepares its victim, as it were for death; in which the struggle between soul and body is so gradual, quiet and solemn, that day by day, and grain by grain, the mortal part wastes and withers, and the spirit part grows light and sanguine with its lightening load; a disease which medicine never cured, wealth warded off, or poverty could boast exemption from - which sometimes moves in giant's strides, and sometimes at a tardy, sluggish pace, but slow or quick is ever sure and certain. Nicholas resolved to take Smike to the country for some healthy country air. Dividing the distance into two days' journey, Nicholas and Smike found themselves in the village where Nicholas had grown up.

NICHOLAS: Look, there's our garden, Smike. That's where we used to play, and run, and hide.

SMIKE: You used to hide?

NICHOLAS: Yes, Smike, you know, the game.

SMIKE: Is it the same. As when. Is it the same.

NICHOLAS: Things look a little different, Smike. The tree looks smaller. A the garden has become a little overgrown. But still - it is the same.

NARRATOR: And in a fortnight, Smike became too ill to move about. And he would lie upon an old couch, near the open doors that led into a little orchard. And Nicholas would sit with him and talk for hours and hours together. Till the sun went down, and Smike would fall asleep.

SMIKE: Who calls? So calls so loud? Who calls so loud?

NICHOLAS: Come hither, man. I see that thou art poor. Hold, there is forty ducats. Let me have -

SMIKE: Such mortal drugs I have, but Mantua's law Is - is-

NICHOLAS: Oh, Smike.

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SMIKE: Is death to any he that utters them. (Prompting) Art thou so bare?

NICHOLAS: Art thou so bare and full or wretchedness, and fears to die? Famine is in thy cheeks, need and oppression starveth in thy eyes. Contempt and -

SMIKE: No. No, I don't fear to die. My will consents. You know I think, that if I could rise up again, completely well, I wouldn't want to, now. For nothing - can be ill if she be well.

NICHOLAS: Then she is well, and nothing can be ill. Her body sleeps in Capel's monument. But her immortal part with angels lives.

SMIKE: Is it. E'en so? I see a garden. Trees and happy children's faces. And her body sleeps. Light on the faces. Living with the angles. Dreamt my lady came and found me dead. Such happy dreams. I'm going home. Who calls. Who calls so loud?

NICHOLAS: He said - I think you know. And then he said he was in Eden.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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